

# Ankana Saha

Ph.D. Candidate · Linguistics

Department of Linguistics, Harvard University  
Boylston Hall, 3rd Floor, Cambridge, MA 02138  
✉ [ankana\\_saha@g.harvard.edu](mailto:ankana_saha@g.harvard.edu)  
🌐 [sites.google.com/g.harvard.edu/ankanasaha](https://sites.google.com/g.harvard.edu/ankanasaha)

## Research Interests

Cross-linguistic experimental semantics & pragmatics, semantic theory, computational pragmatics, semantic fieldwork

## Education

- 2019–present **Ph.D. in Linguistics, Harvard University, Cambridge, USA**  
Thesis: *The Anatomy of Definiteness* (expected Fall 2025)  
Advisors: Gennaro Chierchia, Kathryn Davidson (co-chair), Veneeta Dayal (Yale University).
- 2015–2017 **M.A. in Linguistics, The English and Foreign Languages University, Hyderabad, India**  
Graduated with distinction (top of class). GPA: 7.64/8.
- 2011–2014 **B.Sc. in Physics, Chemistry, and Mathematics, Christ University, Bangalore, India**  
First Class with Distinction (81%).
- Non-degree Studies
- 2023 Linguistic Institute of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA), UMass Amherst
- 2022 North American Summer School in Logic, Language, and Information (NASSLLI), University of Southern California
- 2019 CreteLing Summer School, University of Crete
- 2018 CreteLing Summer School, University of Crete
- 2018 Linguistics Summer School in the Indian Mountains (LISSIM 11), Solang Valley

## Publications

### Conference Proceedings

- 2025 Hu, Jennifer\*, **Ankana Saha\*** & Kathryn Davidson. “The or That? Evaluating language models’ sensitivity to discourse structure in anaphora.” *Pragmatic Reasoning in Language Models Workshop at COLM 2025*.
- 2025 **Saha, Ankana**. “Demonstrative descriptions and anti-uniqueness.” *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung (SuB) 29*.
- 2024 **Saha, Ankana**, Yağmur Sağ, Jian Cui & Kathryn Davidson. “Anaphoric demonstratives in Mandarin.” *Proceedings of Semantics and Linguistic Theory (SALT) 34*.
- 2023 **Saha, Ankana**, Yağmur Sağ & Kathryn Davidson. “Anaphoric demonstratives in Mandarin.” *Proceedings of SALT 33*.
- 2023 **Saha, Ankana**. “Reference to kinds: the perspective from Bangla.” *Proceedings of WCCFL 41*.
- 2020 Ahn, Dorothy, **Ankana Saha** & Uli Sauerland. “Positively Polar Plurals.” *Proceedings of SALT 30*.

---

## Presentations

### Invited Talks

- 2025 (upcoming) *Discourse Reasoning in Humans and Artificial Language Systems*. University of Pennsylvania. TBD.
- 2025 (upcoming) *From Humans to Language Models: Testing the Boundaries of Pragmatic Understanding*. Language & Cognition Seminar, Harvard University. November 11, 2025.
- 2025 *Bridging Modalities: Tracking Reference in Discourse Across Spoken and Sign Language*. Linguistic Meaning Lab, Cornell University. October 10, 2025.
- 2021 *The typology of free choice and polarity in Bangla*. Semantics Reading Group, Yale University. November 2021.

### Conference Presentations

- 2026 (upcoming) Wang, Xiaotian, **Ankana Saha** & Kathryn Davidson. "Code-switching in Mandarin and English Definite Noun Phrases." Talk at the *2026 Annual Meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 2026)*, New Orleans, Louisiana.
- 2025 Wang, Xiaotian, **Ankana Saha** & Kathryn Davidson. "The Expression of Strong Definiteness in Code-switched Context." Poster at the *15th International Symposium on Bilingualism (ISB15)*, Donostia–San Sebastián.
- 2025 Hu, Jennifer\*, **Ankana Saha**\* & Kathryn Davidson. "The or That? Evaluating language models' sensitivity to discourse structure in anaphora." Spotlight talk at the *Conference on Language Modeling (COLM 2025)*, Montreal, Canada.
- 2024 **Saha, Ankana**. "Demonstratives and alternatives." Talk at *Sinn und Bedeutung 29 (SuB 29)*, Noto, Sicily.
- 2024 **Saha, Ankana** & Kathryn Davidson. "Distinctions in anaphoricity: German strong definites vs. demonstratives." Poster at the *5th Experimental Pragmatics in Italy Conference (XPRAG.it 2024)*, Venice, Italy.
- 2024 **Saha, Ankana**, Yağmur Sağ, Jian Cui & Kathryn Davidson. "Mandarin demonstratives as strong definites: An experimental investigation." Talk at the *Experiments in Linguistic Meaning (ELM 3)*, University of Pennsylvania.
- 2024 **Saha, Ankana**, Yağmur Sağ, Jian Cui & Kathryn Davidson. "Mandarin demonstratives as strong definites." Poster at *Semantics and Linguistic Theory (SALT 34)*, University of Rochester.
- 2023 Schwarz, Florian, Agata Renans, Hasiyatu Abubakari, Dorothy Ahn, Fenna Bergsma, Nattanu Chanchaochai, Reginald Duah, Imke Driemel, Ljudmila Geist, Mira Grubic, Sampson Korsah, Suet-Ying Lam, Cecile Meier, Yağmur Sağ, **Ankana Saha**, Radek Šimik, and Alexandra Simonenko. "Two types of definites — cross-linguistic experimental study." Talk at the *Cross-linguistic Perspectives on Processing and Learning (X-PPL 2023)*, University of Zurich.
- 2023 **Saha, Ankana**, Yağmur Sağ & Kathryn Davidson. "Focus on demonstratives: Experiments in English and Turkish." Poster at *Semantics and Linguistic Theory (SALT 33)*, Yale University.
- 2023 **Saha, Ankana**. "Reference to kinds: the perspective from Bangla." Talk at the *West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 41)*, UC Santa Cruz.
- 2023 **Saha, Ankana**. "Reference to kinds: the perspective from Bangla." Poster at the *Workshop on (In)definiteness and Genericity*, Yale University.

- 2023 **Saha, Ankana.** "Focus on demonstratives: Experiments in English and Turkish." *Harvard Mind Brain Behavior Interfaculty Initiative Showcase*, Harvard University.
- 2022 **Saha, Ankana.** "Free choice and epistemicity in Bangla: A test for exhaustification-based approaches." Talk at the *46th Annual Penn Linguistics Conference (PLC 46)*, University of Pennsylvania.
- 2022 **Saha, Ankana.** "The typology of free choice and polarity in Bangla." Talk at the *14th Annual Western Interdisciplinary Student Symposium on Language Research (WISSLR 2022)*, Western University.
- 2022 **Saha, Ankana.** "Free choice and epistemicity in Bangla." Poster at the *12th Formal Approaches to South Asian Languages (FASAL 12)*, University of Utah.
- 2022 **Saha, Ankana.** "The puzzle of kind reference in Bangla." Talk at the *Southern New England Workshop in Semantics (SNEWS)*, Yale University.
- 2020 Ahn, Dorothy, **Ankana Saha** & Uli Sauerland. "Positively Polar Plurals." Poster at *Semantics and Linguistic Theory (SALT 30)*, Cornell University.

## --- Honors & Awards

- 2024–2025 XXIII Frontier Fellowship, Harvard Griffin Graduate School of Arts and Sciences
- 2024 Graduate Research Award, The Institute for Quantitative Social Science (IQSS), Harvard University (\$3,000)
- 2024 Professional Development Award, Graduate School of Arts and Sciences, Harvard University (\$2,500)
- 2024 Young Investigator and Graduate Student Research Award, Harvard Mind Brain Behavior Interfaculty Initiative (\$5,550)
- 2023–2024 Amartya Sen Fellowship for Students from India, Harvard University
- 2023 Certificate of Student Recognition of Teaching, Harvard University
- 2022–2023 Amartya Sen Fellowship for Students from India, Harvard University
- 2022 Young Investigator and Graduate Student Research Award, Harvard Mind Brain Behavior Interfaculty Initiative (\$1,275)
- 2022 NSF Student Grant, North American Summer School in Logic, Language, and Information (NASSLLI) (\$800)
- 2020 Harvard Summer School Language Fellowship, Harvard University (\$3,340)
- 2019–2020 Amartya Sen Fellowship for Students from India, Harvard University
- 2018 Merit Grant, CreteLing Summer School
- 2017 Assistant Professorship in Linguistics, National Eligibility Test (NET), University Grants Commission of India

## --- Professional Experience

- 2025 Curriculum Developer, LING 10: Language, Harvard University
- 2025 Lab Manager, Meaning and Modality Lab, Harvard University
- 2023–2024 Assistant Head Tutor, Department of Linguistics, Harvard University
- 2023 Research Coordinator, Meaning and Modality Lab, Harvard University
- 2021–2024 Graduate Teaching Fellow (TF), Harvard University
- 2021 Project Advisor, Ivypedia (freelance, remote)

- 2021 Mentor in Linguistics, Lumiere Education (freelance, remote)
- 2020 Instructor of Linguistics, ViaX Online Education (freelance, remote)
- 2017 Editor - Social Science, XAMCHECK, India
- 2017 Editorial Intern - Global Academic Publishing, Oxford University Press, India
- 2016 Editorial Intern, Orient BlackSwan, India
- 2016 Experiential Learning Facilitator, KAARMIC Education Services, India
- 2014–2015 Developmental Editor, ANSRSource Inc., India

## Research & Fieldwork

- 2023 Visiting Researcher, Leibniz-Centre General Linguistics (ZAS), Berlin. Advisor: Uli Sauerland. Project: "Optional Plural Marking."
- 2022 Research Assistant, Department of Linguistics, Boston University. Advisor: Kate Lindsey. Project: "Pahoturi River Language Documentation."
- 2022 Fieldwork on IciBemba (Bantu)
- 2021 Fieldwork on Assamese and Odia (Indo-Aryan)

## Teaching

### Harvard University

- |             |                                                    |                                       |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Fall 2025   | LING 10: Language                                  | (Curriculum developer, undergraduate) |
| Summer 2025 | LING S-101: The Science of Language                | (Head Instructor, undergraduate)      |
| Spring 2024 | LING 83: Language, Structure, and Cognition        | (Head TF, undergraduate)              |
| Spring 2023 | LING 83: Language, Structure, and Cognition        | (TF, undergraduate)                   |
| Fall 2022   | LING 116: Semantic Theory I                        | (TF, graduate)                        |
| Fall 2022   | LING 98A: Semantics of Modification                | (Head Instructor, undergraduate)      |
| Spring 2022 | LING 106: Knowledge of Meaning                     | (TF, undergraduate)                   |
| Fall 2021   | LING 101: The Science of Language: An Introduction | (TF, undergraduate)                   |

### The English and Foreign Languages University, India

- |             |                            |                |
|-------------|----------------------------|----------------|
| Spring 2019 | LS 252: Advanced Semantics | (TA, graduate) |
| Fall 2018   | LS 151: Semantics I        | (TA, graduate) |

## Service

- 2025 Reviewer, *Semantics and Linguistic Theory (SALT 35)*
- 2024–2025 Lead Student Organizer, SALT 35, Harvard University
- 2024–2025 Reviewer, *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory*
- 2024 Reviewer, *Sinn und Bedeutung (SuB) 29*
- 2022–2023 Co-organizer, Harvard Department of Linguistics Universals Workshop
- 2021–2022 Co-organizer, Harvard Department of Linguistics Circle Workshop
- 2020–2021 Coordinator, Southern New England Workshop in Semantics (SNEWS)
- 2020 Co-organizer, Semantics Triangle @ MIT, Harvard University, & Boston Unoversity

---

## Miscellany

Languages English, Bangla (native); Hindi (fluent); Spanish (conversational)  
Membership Linguistic Society of America, Cognitive Science Society